# 11.1 Resonance

WORKSHEET

**The question**

**STEP II 1991, Question 12**

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/91-s2-q12

## Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

**Ask yourself** The particle hangs in equilibrium with extension $c$. If the string has modulus $\lambda$, what is the relation between $\lambda$, $a$, $c$, $m$ and $g$? What is the extension when the top has moved down by $b\sin pt$ and the particle by $x$?

### STAGE 2 Solving

**Ask yourself** The equation is $\ddot{x} + n^2x = n^2b\sin pt$. Try a particular solution of the form $x = C\sin pt$. Then add the general solution of $\ddot{x} + n^2x = 0$. Which initial conditions does the particle satisfy?

### STAGE 3 Staying taut

**Ask yourself** The string is taut exactly when its extension is positive. Write the extension $c + x - b\sin pt$ in terms of $t$.

**Ask yourself** How negative can $p\sin pt - n\sin nt$ possibly be?

**Pause and try** What happens to this condition as $p$ approaches $n$? How small must the shaking amplitude $b$ be when $p = 0.9n$? When $p = 0.99n$?

## Try this next

1 **A falling lift.** (From STEP II, 1996.) A particle hangs from the ceiling of a lift by an elastic string, extended by $a$. The lift starts to descend with constant acceleration $f < \frac{g}{2}$. Show that the extension $y$ of the string satisfies $\ddot{y} + \frac{g}{a}y = g - f$, that the string never becomes slack, and that the oscillation has amplitude $\frac{af}{g}$. After time $T$ the lift stops accelerating. Show that the amplitude becomes $\frac{2af}{g}|\sin\frac{1}{2}\omega T|$, where $\omega^2 = \frac{g}{a}$.

2 **At resonance.** Solve $\ddot{x} + n^2x = n^2b\sin nt$ with $x(0) = \dot{x}(0) = 0$ directly, by trying a particular solution $x = Ct\cos nt$. Check that it agrees with the limit above.

3 **Beats.** Show that $n\sin pt - p\sin nt$ can be written as a sum of two terms, one of which is approximately $2n\cos\frac{(n+p)t}{2}\sin\frac{(p-n)t}{2}$ when $p$ is close to $n$. Hence explain the beat period $\frac{2\pi}{n-p}$.

4 **Damped resonance.** For $\ddot{x} + 2k\dot{x} + n^2x = F\cos pt$ with small $k > 0$, find the steady-state amplitude, and show that it is greatest when $p^2 = n^2 - 2k^2$.

## Further reading

- **A. P. French, *Vibrations and Waves*** (MIT Introductory Physics Series). Chapter 4 on forced oscillations and resonance is the classic account.
- **Steven Strogatz, *Sync*** (Penguin). How things fall into step, from fireflies to the Millennium Bridge.
- **Henry Petroski, *To Engineer Is Human*** (Vintage). Engineering failures, including the bridges in the history box.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 11.1:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch11/resonance.html